Plan a circle: “The Gift of the Magi”

O. Henry (1905) · public-domain short story · grades 7–10 · ~1 week / two meetings. Rights: Public domain.

Kit section 5 (group agreement & calendar) filled in for one text — a finished plan students see before writing their own. ***Tinted italic*** = sample answers.

Text, group, and target

Text / author / edition	***“The Gift of the Magi” — O. Henry (1905). Public-domain short story.***
Group / period / dates	***Maya’s group · Period __ · Meetings ___ & ___***
Grade / TEKS target (p. 3)	Grade 8 · §110.24 — 7(A): theme through characters/events; 6(C,D): support inferences; 1(D): student-led discussion.
Learning intention	We are learning to explain how the characters’ choices reveal a theme about love and value.
Success criteria	I bring one open question, cite two details with paragraph numbers, respond to a peer, and name how my thinking changed.

Reading map & calendar

Chunk	Read through	Meeting date · leader
1	***Opening through Della selling her hair and buying the watch chain (≈ paragraphs 1–20).***	***Tue · Leader: Maya***
2	***Jim arrives home through the closing “magi” paragraph — the double reveal (≈ paragraphs 21–end).***	***Thu · Leader: Devon***

Members & first-meeting jobs (p. 7 roles)

Member	First job	Rotates to (next meeting)
Maya	***Questioner***	***Summarizer***
Devon	***Summarizer***	***Clarifier***
Priya	***Clarifier***	***Evidence tracker***
Luis	***Predictor***	***Questioner***

Text-specific discussion questions (open — more than one answer)

- **Predict:** After Della counts $1.87 the day before Christmas, what will she risk to give Jim a worthy gift? What clue supports your guess?
- **Question:** Why might the narrator step in to compare Della and Jim to the magi? How does that change how we judge their choices?
- **Clarify:** What does the narrator mean that they “most unwisely sacrificed the greatest treasures”? Is it really unwise?
- **Summarize:** Each sold the one thing the other’s gift was meant for — restate that irony in order, without opinion.
- **Interpret the theme:** How do their choices reveal what the story says about love versus money? Use two details.

> **Optional Jigsaw lenses (p. 4):** ***Character*** (Della’s and Jim’s choices) · ***Plot*** (the parallel sacrifices, twist ending) · ***Language*** (the intruding narrator) · ***Theme*** (value isn’t material) · ***Point of view*** (the narrator’s direct address (5th reader)).

Sample 3–2–1 notes: Priya, character choices lens

Name: Priya · Home group: Maya's group · Period __ · Meetings ___ & ___ · Section: "The Gift of the Magi," Chunk 2 · Expert lens: Character choices

What a finished prep looks like. Kit section 6 / Organizer A completed for one reader, so students can compare their notes to a strong model.

Questions ***Is a gift that can't be used still the best gift?*** ***Why call them the "wisest" right after calling the trade unwise?***	**3 · Important ideas** ***1. Jim sells his gold watch — his most prized possession — to buy Della combs.*** ***2. Della had already cut and sold her long hair to buy Jim a chain for that watch.*** ***3. Neither can use the gift they receive, yet both are moved, not angry.***
Vocabulary ***coveted = wanted badly for a long time.*** ***the magi = the wise gift-bringers of the Christmas story.***	**2 · Supporting details** ***1. When Jim sees Della's short hair he goes still — shock, not anger (the reveal). → His love isn't about her appearance.*** ***2. The combs Della had "coveted" are now useless without her hair (the reveal). → The gift's worth is in the sacrifice.***

1 · Summary in my own words

Both Della and Jim secretly sold their most treasured thing to buy the other a Christmas gift. The gifts can't even be used — but the love and sacrifice behind them is the real point.

Bring to the circle

My interpretation: ***These details suggest the story measures love by what people give up, not by what they spend.***
Synthesis (two lenses): ***The parallel sacrifices (plot) create the irony that proves the theme: value lives in the sacrifice, not the object. Text points: Della's haircut in Chunk 1 and Jim's sold watch in Chunk 2.***
After discussion: ***My thinking became clearer once the group compared evidence.***

TEKS evidence: 6(C,D) supported inference; 7(A) theme through characters/events; 1(D) response to a peer. · Pair with the PlotPoint "The Gift of the Magi" room.